

almost a thousand dollars in some cases for a tablet that has no promise of a single update as soon as you walk it out the door, you should have a pretty good idea. Apple gets to set the stage for pricing with its mammoth lead in the tablet market, but Android tablets have yet to take advantage of this and undercut Apple's pricing. It's corporate suicide to many, and such a turn-off that it seems like manufacturers and carriers alike are trying to make Android fail.

Microsoft has a huge chance here. Undercutting Android's pricing across the board with its tablet offerings will give Redmond a mighty advantage, especially in this economy. The numbers show that consumers want tablets, and want them bad. It's obvious that Apple is giving them the price point plus the ease of use to make Cupertino the overwhelming winner thus far. Microsoft's familiar Windows interface plus an aggressive pricing model could put a stranglehold on Android tablets so tight they'll never get their groove and take off.

The long and short of it is there's room in the tablet war for a third contender, and Microsoft has a chance to really make a splash on the scene.

BlackBerry PlayBook

RIM has been billing their BlackBerry PlayBook tablet as an iPad killer ever since it first revealed it way back in September 2010. With a greater focus on enterprise usage than the iPad 2, its smaller 7-inch form factor makes it a very different proposition from that of Apple's slate offering.

There can be only one slate at the top of the tablet pile; does the PlayBook have what it takes to knock the iPad off its lofty perch? With pricing and storage relatively balanced across each device, we focus here on breaking down the key tablet features to see which tablet is worthy of your cash.

Size and Design

The first and most obvious difference between the two tablets is their size. The BlackBerry PlayBook is a 7-inch device with dimensions of 193 x 130 x 10mm and a weight of 400g, while the iPad 2 is a 10.1 inch tablet with dimensions of 241x186x9mm, with the top-spec 3G model weighing a heavier 610g.

iPad 2 has a physical home button on the bottom of its bezel; the BlackBerry PlayBook has no buttons on its front side, making for a very slick and smooth front face, even if the black boxy design of RIM's unit is a little uninspired overall. The tiny power button on the PlayBook is a chore to find though.